

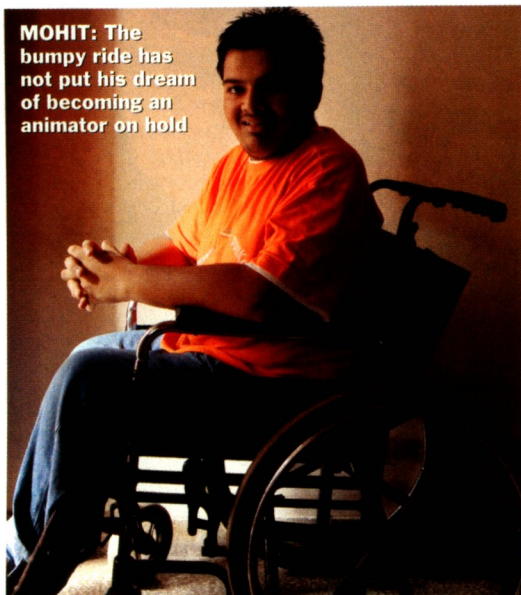
NEW MOBILITY

■ By Damayanti Datta

Mohit Gupta's wacky e-mail id (*no.dandruff@...*) holds clue to his teen life. His days and nights are abuzz with cell phone tunes, IM pings and computer runs to see if he has been "friended" on MySpace or "Facebooked". Switched on and charged up, the world is at his fingertips. But not his city. Parks, malls and multiplexes have been out of bounds for the Delhi boy for the last 12 years—ever since a spinal tumour took away his mobility. He has been refused admission by umpteen schools, shifted endlessly, forced to opt out of lectures and to study with mentally-slow students. Now, after Class XII, his dream of becoming an animator has hit a roadblock: "The classes are all on upper floors or in basements. How would a wheelchair-user like me attend lectures?" No wonder, he has another e-mail id, *mohit.pains@...*

It's not just a dismal story of a nation failing a boy. For, Mohit is hardly alone. He is yet another face among the nation's countless "special people"—caught between the void of confined inactivity and a system that's yet to develop sensitivity toward the medically-fragile. But changes are afoot. "Inclusion" is the new Government mantra, a Rs 1,000-crore secondary education scheme for the disabled is awaiting Cabinet approval and an amendment of India's disability laws is on the anvil. Last

MOHIT: The bumpy ride has not put his dream of becoming an animator on hold



HAVI S. SAMANI

Roads, buildings, transport—nothing caters to people with special needs. But mindsets are changing. A clutch of initiatives promises to open up a better world for the differently-abled.



NEW INITIATIVES

- HRD Ministry working on a Rs 1,000-crore secondary education scheme for disabled students
- Central Advisory Board on Education preparing database in all states
- Amendment of India's

disability laws on the anvil; private sector may figure

- Sunrise sectors of IT, ITES, KPO, BPO, hospitality and retail recruiting the differently-abled
- Universal barrier-free design being used more and more in public space and transport, especially in the capital.

month, the Central Advisory Board on Education—India's apex education advisory body—hailed up states for not having "effective" and "accurate" facts and figures on special children. "While 16 states had paltry data, the rest couldn't even produce any. We were shocked," says a member on conditions of anonymity.

Mohit doesn't know that his country is clueless about people like him. "India's attitude has been: No Census, no statistics, no problem," says Javed Abidi, a wheelchair-user and a major voice for people with